

From the Editor

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The eight articles appearing in this issue advance project management research along two directions. First, they question the underlying current assumptions of project management and propose alternative perspectives. Second, they bring forward emerging research methods to investigate the research problems in a novel way.

The first article is “Advancing Project Management: Authenticating the Shift From Process to ‘Nuanced’ Project-Based Management in the Ambidextrous Organization” (Leybourne & Sainter). The purpose of this article is to advocate for a new project management paradigm that is more flexible and organic as opposed to the current normative perspective. The authors draw on the literature from ambidextrous organizations. Just as ambidextrous organizations operate in conditions of uncertainty and complexity, projects also face a similar challenge from their context. Thus, drawing a parallel between ambidextrous organizational research and project complexity research, the authors bring forward hard and soft systems of projects that need to be standardized, and that are required to be flexible. In support of their argument, the authors state that standardization of certain aspects of a project, such as processes, tools, and leadership, leads to project success. On the other hand, standardizing project organization structure, culture, and performance metrics has limited impact on project success. Further, it is argued that the project practitioners entering the workforce have a greater proclivity to work in complex project environments and therefore are better able to embrace new tenets of project organizations. Interestingly, the authors point to how this interest in acknowledging and managing complexity in projects is not restricted to practice alone, but also to project management education. Based on these arguments, a new model of project management paradigm is proposed where the project planning and execution are merged so as to better manage the uncertainty, ambiguity, and complexity inherent in the project.

The second paper appearing in this issue is “Establishing Project Portfolio Management: An Exploratory Analysis of the Influence of Internal Stakeholders’ Interactions” by Beringer, Jonas, and Gemünden. This article takes the discussion on the changing nature of project management forward, proposing alternative ways to

practice project portfolio management by understanding stakeholder behavior across project portfolio management phases. Two major research questions are put forward: (1) to what extent are different stakeholders engaged with their respective project portfolio management processes? and (2) how does the interaction between the stakeholders affect the intensity of a stakeholder’s engagement to a Project Portfolio Management Process Group? First, the extant literature on portfolio management that includes prioritization and management of resources across the projects in a portfolio is presented. The three major Process Groups—Portfolio Structuring, Resource Management, and Portfolio Steering—are explained. Next, the research on stakeholder management, especially in the context of project portfolio management, is presented. In line with the research questions, the scope of this study is restricted to strategic stakeholders: senior managers, middle level managers, project portfolio managers, and project managers. The authors contacted 223 project portfolio firms from Austria, Germany, and Switzerland, and those that had at least 20 simultaneous active projects within their portfolio were considered as a sample for the empirical investigation. The survey included 426 managers from these firms. A percentage analysis, followed by correlation analysis, revealed that senior management is strongly engaged with portfolio structuring, while line managers are engaged with resource management. Project portfolio managers are engaged with portfolio steering. Interestingly, project managers are not closely engaged with any of these three Process Groups. Further, role clarity affects the intensity of engagement between the project stakeholders in a particular project portfolio management phase.

The third article appearing in this issue is “Portfolio Management: The Australian Experience” (Koh & Crawford). As in the second article of this issue, this article refines our understanding of project portfolio management by focusing on the governance structures and the roles and responsibilities of project portfolio managers. The broad research question posed is: How different are the roles and responsibilities of project portfolio managers? A qualitative study using an inductive interview-based approach with six portfolio managers from service

and manufacturing organizations in Australia was conducted. The themes of the semi-structured interviews on portfolio management mainly focused on strategic alignment, portfolio prioritization and selection, stakeholder management, risk management, resource planning, value assessment, and benefits realization. The findings suggest that the roles and responsibilities of portfolio managers were similar in both manufacturing and service industries. However, the emphasis to deliver value through projects is greater in the case of service organizations than in manufacturing organizations. On the other hand, the portfolio managers in manufacturing work more closely with the sales and marketing team to monitor their competitor's strategies on product development than their counterparts from the service sector.

The fourth article is titled "How Effective Are Project Management Methodologies? An Explorative Evaluation of Their Benefits in Practice" (Wells). The focus shifts from managing portfolios to understanding the relationship between project management methodologies and business performance. This article investigates the benefits and support provided by project management methodologies to project managers for the management and delivery of information technology/information system (IT/IS) projects. An inductive research method with exploratory case studies was used to investigate the research problem. A total of 48 respondents from 4 organizations were interviewed. Further, a combination of interpretative and content analysis was employed using a general inductive approach for qualitative data analysis, and for triangulating the results. These resulted in the development of four case studies from these four organizations. Case 1 focused on PRINCE2®, a widely used structured project management methodology (PMM). Case 2 concerned an in-house structured PMM. Case 3 employed a gate-phased PMM. Case 4 hosted a gate-phased PMM in the process of being phased out and replaced by an agile approach. The general consensus across the cases was that traditional, structured PMMs were beneficial for projects and organizations. However, the types of perceived benefit and contribution were different, depending on the individual, his or her level of involvement with the project, his or her accountability, and the organization. Further, methodologies also help in the standardization of project processes, which results in their being better understood by diverse stakeholders. This is especially important to manage uncertainty, and therefore act as a guide to the managers.

The fifth article being published in this issue is "Challenging Classic Project Management: Turning Project Uncertainties Into Business Opportunities" by Lechler, Edington, and Gao. As in the previous article by Wells, this article questions the value of project management to business. More specifically, it attempts

to differentiate between risks and uncertainties in projects, and proposes how uncertainties can be converted into business opportunities. Semi-structured interviews of 19 project managers involved in different types of information technology projects were completed, which resulted in 20 exploratory studies. Four categories of opportunities arising from project uncertainty were identified: technical innovation, opportunities related to implementation process, business opportunity, and future project business opportunity. Further, six categories of uncertainty were identified: contextual, stakeholder, technological, organizational, project, and malpractice. Finally, specific opportunities that can be leveraged from project uncertainty, and their value to a project are presented.

The sixth article for this issue is titled "Learning From Project Management Implementation by Applying a Management Innovation Lens" by Thomas, Cicmil, and George. This article focuses on innovation in project management implementation by drawing extensively from management innovation and organizational change literature. The objectives of this article are threefold: (1) explore how project implementation can be meaningfully explained by management innovation; (2) understand the antecedents, processes, and outcomes of management innovation; and (3) identify the managerial implications of such innovations in project management implementation. An operational framework of management innovation, based on its pace (cumulative or episodic), and scope (convergent or radical), was used for the purpose of the study. Project implementation practices from 48 project organizations were studied using quasi-experimental design. This included conducting interviews, surveys, and reviewing project related documents. Findings suggest that successful innovations can be brought about from project implementation by bringing in a revolutionary idea. Successful innovations also require support from the organizations' executive management. On the other hand, the least successful innovations were episodic in nature.

The seventh article being published in this issue is "Metaphor Interactions to Develop Team Relationships and Robustness Enhance Project Outcomes" (Shelley). The unit of analysis for this article is the project team. The purpose of this article is to understand the appropriate behaviors of team members that lead to team performance. Reflective performance cycle as a theoretical lens is applied to the research problem within which metaphors are used to stimulate constructive conversations between team members leading to team performance. Action research methods were applied where three types of participants—late career professionals, mid-career professionals, and early career professionals—participated

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in an exercise, where they were exposed to metaphors representing project actors such as a project leader. Desirable and undesirable behaviors of managers that would affect team performance were identified. While inspirational leadership was strongly favored by all participants, there were differences on the command and control style of leadership among the participants, ranging from desirable to undesirable. Late career professionals were clearer about the most appropriate managerial behavior than the early or mid-career professionals. Such differences between the actors triggered constructive conversation. Further, the use of metaphors triggered intuitive recognition/identification with the objects, which therefore led to richer discussions and reflection among the actors, thus affecting project outcomes.

The last article for this issue is “Simultaneous Pursuit of Innovation and Efficiency in Complex Engineering Projects—A Study of the Antecedents and Impacts of Ambidexterity in Project Teams” (Liu & Leitner). The purpose of this article is to understand the complex infrastructure project, which faces unique challenges and tight budget and schedule, and investigates

the antecedents of ambidexterity and the effect of ambidexterity on project performance. The authors posit that contextual ambidexterity focuses on creating an environment that empowers individuals to make a choice between exploration (searching for and finding new approaches/processes) and exploitation (incrementally improving existing processes) activities in their daily work. In order to address this research problem, a complex civil works construction project in New Zealand was developed as a case study. A survey of 38 project workers was used for this project. The findings of the study conclude that ambidexterity at the project team level is an antecedent to project performance. Further, the effects of temporal separation and project context on project performance are mediated by the project team's degree of ambidexterity; and finally, structural separation is not a determinant of the project team's ambidexterity.

Enjoy reading this issue!

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